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Professor Name

Subject Name

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Hypnotized

“Nice of you to finally show up,” Eric remarks as he opens his front door.

Rolling her eyes, Mina walked right past him and into the kitchen, dropping a grey Walmart bag onto the kitchen table. “Then find your own bag of family-size extra spicy chili cheese potato chips next time,” she retorted. “For something that I’ve never heard of before, it’s surprisingly popular and hard to find.”

Eric closed and locked the door behind him as he went to join her in the kitchen. “And that is why I *love* you, dearest friend. Now get in the living room, go. Everyone’s waiting.” He rushed her to the living room, giving her back light taps. The two make their way into the living room where their other two friends are seated on the sofa watching whatever cartoon was on the television.

“Wassup biatches,” she greeted them, plopping herself down between the two of them.

“Thank god, you’re here!” Kira pounces on her as soon as she notices her presence.

“Eric’s kept us holed up in this stupid living room watching stupid We Bare Bares for an hour now and he has *no* food.”

“Hey! We Bare Bears is *not* stupid.” Matt argues from Mina’s other side.

“It is when we’re *starving*. PLEASE tell me you brought food with you.” Kira begs.

“He made me go to Walmart and get those disgusting chips he likes,” she explained.

Groaning, hungry and defeated, Kira gets up off the couch. “You know what? It goes against all my morals to eat that bag of diabetes but I haven’t eaten in hours so.” She signs a cross over her chest before walking into the kitchen and opening the bag.

“She has a point, Eric,” Matt speaks. “Why have you summoned us here at 10 p.m. on a Friday?” Not like he had anything to do anyway.

Eric had sent a text in the group chat begging them to come over immediately.

“Well,” he starts, sitting in front of them on the coffee table, hands together, just as Kira comes back into the living room munching on the giant bag of chips in her hand. “As you know, I’m moving in a week, and I probably won’t see you guys again for a while.”

About a month ago Eric had been given the news that his family was moving to Manchester, England to stay with his father’s side of the family. He hadn’t been taking the news very well, but ever since yesterday he’d seemed to be doing good.

“Yeah yeah, super sad stuff.” Mina starts, “So why are we here?”

“Well, when we were clearing the stuff out of the attic, I found a box of stuff from my great grandfather.”

“The magician?” Kira speaks, mouth full.

“Yeah him! Now, this box had a bunch of his old-timey magician stuff in it, and guess what I found,” he asks, an enthusiastic smile on his face.

“Ooh!” Mina raises her hand eagerly. “Dead pigeon!”

The smile drops from Eric’s face. “What? No!”

“Why would it be a dead pigeon?” Matt turns to her, both alarm and confusion on his face.

“You know how magicians make those pigeons fly out their hats.” She explains as if it’s obvious.

Matt just stares at her for a second. “First of all, those are doves,” He deadpans.

“Fine then, he found a dead dove.” Mina corrects.

“I thought those were the birds that attacked me in the park for my bagel...” Kira speaks, confused and her mouth still full of chips.

“Kira honey, those were geese.” Matt corrects.

“So he found a dead goose,” Mina speaks up again.

“ENOUGH ABOUT THE DEAD BIRDS. THERE ARE NO DEAD BIRDS!” Eric shouts, tired of the bird talk. His outburst causes his friends to quiet down, giving him the floor to continue.

“What I found was this,” he reaches into the pocket of his sweatshirt and pulls out a small gold clock with a chain attached to it. He holds it up in front of his friends expecting them to marvel at it just as he was, but their reactions are less than.

“An old dirty pocket watch...” Matt speaks. “Yay?”

“Oooh, are we gonna pawn it off for money?” Mina perks up.

“Yeah, maybe we’ll have money for some *real* food,” Kira complains, shaking the bag of chips.

“Well you seem to like them right now,” he leans over and snatches them out of her hand.

“And stop eating them all, they’re for me!”

“And this isn’t any ordinary pocket watch. My great-grandfather used this countless times to hypnotize people at his shows. *Successfully.*” He waits for their reactions.

“Crickets.”

“Mina!” Matt hits her on the arm.

“What? We were all thinking it!” She raises her hands in defense.

“I’m sorry dude,” Matt tries to explain after seeing Eric’s disappointed reaction. “We were just hoping to be here at 10 o’clock at night to do more than just look at an old pocket watch.”

“Oh, we’re not just here to look at it.” Eric smiles a sinister kind of smile at the group, earning him suspicious looks.

“We’re here to use it.”

“I, for one, think this is absolutely ridiculous,” Kira says as she watches the black and white watch face sway back and forth in front of her face, eyes eventually crossing.

“I, for two, second that.” Mina agrees, kneeling at the side of the bed.

The four friends were currently upstairs in Eric’s bedroom testing out the watch and its “hypnotic powers”. Kira had volunteered herself first and was sitting at the edge of the bed, as Eric knelt in front of her, concentratedly swaying the pocketwatch in front of her face. Matt stood on the side of Eric, arms crossed in skepticism, while Mina knelt on the side, observing.

“Just give it a couple more minutes. Trust me, it’ll work.” Eric speaks in a low voice, too concentrated on the task at hand.

“So let’s say that this absurd thing does work, which it won’t, what are you even gonna do once she gets in the hypnotic state?” Matt asks.

“I say we make her do my math homework,” Mina proposes. “Or my chores. Yeah, I like that one better.”

“Mina, you’re almost 18. You need to start learning to do things for yourself.” Matt complains at her words.

“Yeah. Keyword *almost*.”

“Well, I don’t really think Kira *wants* to do your homework.”

“I changed it to chores, Matt. Chores!”

“Same thing!”

The two friends were too absorbed in their bickering to notice that Eric had started murmuring under his breath. He concentrated on Kira’s face as he chanted under his breath, the only English coming out being the words “stay” and “leave”.

“Do you even know how much a maid service cos- wait what the hell?” Matt stops his sentence as he does a double take on Kira’s face. Noticing his shocked expression, Mina turns back to look at her friend, her jaw dropping. “Holyyyy shiiit.”

Kira sat there, staring emotionlessly back at Eric. She was in the hypnotic state.

“Dude, how the hell did you do that?” Matt asked, mind blown as he knelt down beside Eric, grabbing his shoulder. Mina took her hand and slowly waved it in front of Kira’s face, expecting her to at least blink but she didn’t move a muscle.

“I told you guys it would work,” Eric smirked at his friends, as he admired his work.

“Wait wait wait,” Matt starts as he gets closer to Kira. “Kira, sing your ABCs.” He commands.

“Really? Her ABCs? At least I was gonna make her do something useful.” Mina judges.

“It doesn’t matter what we make her do anyway, 'cause it’s not working,” Matt says as he realizes Kira hasn’t done what he’s asked. She still sat there emotionless.

“Huh,” Mina sighed. “Is she even breathing?” she put a finger under her nose, relieved to feel the warm air.

“It’s working,” Eric speaks. “Just not for you.”

It wasn't so much Eric's words that instilled an uncomfortable feeling in his friends, but the way he said them. His tone was laced with so much malice and cunning, you didn't even have to look at his face to know he was smirking.

"What are you talking about?" Matt asks his friend, in a more serious tone than previously used.

"She only listens to me. I'm pretty sure she can't even hear you guys right now. Well, that is until I tell her to of course." Eric chuckles.

"Huh?" Matt stares back at him, confused.

"Watch." Eric turns back to Kira. "Kira, sing your ABCs," he orders.

His two friends sit there in awe as she sings the children's song and immediately goes back into her trance.

"See?" Eric smiles at them. "Told ya."

"Um, I'm getting a little uncomfortable," Mina speaks, moving to stand up, farther away from the boys.

"Yeah, me too," Matt agrees, getting defensive. "Take her out of whatever trance she's in dude."

"Yeahhh," Eric sighs out and hisses through his teeth, "I'm not gonna be able to do that."

"The hell do you mean, 'you aren't gonna be able to do that.'?"

"Well for starters, I don't like your tone. And second of all, I don't want to."

"Man, whatever sick game you're playing it isn't funny. Wake her the hell up." Matt had gotten on his feet now and all traces of amusement had left both his face and voice.

"And I can't do that," Eric had gotten up as well, making the two boys stand in a face-off.

“And why not?”

“Because I need you guys here. You can’t go.” Although his stance was defiant and his face was stoic, Eric’s eyes were glossy with tears and vulnerability. “I can’t go.”

Realizing his friend was not in the right state of mind, Matt slowly backed away as he spoke. “Listen, Eric, I know you’re going through a lot right now, and this is an extremely hard time for you.” He reached for his phone in his back pocket. “But I need you to wake Kira up, or I’m going to have to call the police.” His voice was low and cautious, yet assertive.

The two boys just stood there for what felt like forever, never taking their eyes off of each other in order to anticipate the other’s next move.

The silence being too long for him, Matt broke first and made a move to turn around and call for help, but it was no use. Eric had already seen him reaching into his back pocket and knew this wasn’t going to go as smoothly as he had hoped.

Before Matt could even move another muscle, Eric grabbed his jaw forcing him to look at the old pocketwatch that he dangled in front of his face. Before Matt could close his eyes, Eric had already said the word “stay” and it was too late.

The arms that Matt had raised to pry Eric’s hand off his jaw fell loosely to his sides, and the strained and fearful face he held had dissipated into an emotionless one as he stared ahead.

Eric sighed, hands on his hips, exhausted from the conflict.

Standing a couple of feet away from the door, Mina was left shocked at what she saw in front of her. During the boys' whole dispute, Mina was standing quietly off to the side, assessing the situation and slowly making her way to the door. She was frozen in place though as she saw another one of her friends get sucked into the hypnotic state that one of their own had put them

in. She was finally starting to understand the situation at hand, and she knew she needed to get out.

Finally recovering, Eric lifted his head and began to scan the room, taking notice of Mina, and sneaking out the door right away.

The two made eye contact.

“Mina,” he sighed out.

Mina made a break for it as she bolted through the upstairs hallway and over to the stairs. Eric, right on her heels had grabbed her wrist before she could even take a step down.

As Eric turned her around to face him, Mina made sure to close her eyes in order to avoid looking at the cursed watch.

“You know what I would’ve missed most about you Mina?” He spoke, a smile on his face. “Your snarky remarks dude. Even though they were kinda mean sometimes, they always made me laugh and put me in a good mood.” He shook his head as he laughed. “But now I don’t have to!”

Eyes still closed, Mina had begun putting pieces together. “Where’s your family Eric? Your parents? Your little sister? It’s 10 o’clock at night, they should be here.” She gritted out.

Her words only caused his smile to grow wider. “Oh, they’re here. You know it’s great actually! They decided that we’re not moving after all!” He laughed out joyfully.

“Change of heart huh?” Mina said sarcastically.

“Yeah. Something like that.” He tilted his head.

As she made her escape, Mina concluded that she had only two options. A) Either pry herself out of his grasp, resulting in her falling backward down the tall flight of stairs. Or B) Open her eyes and make a break for the attic stairs, which may result in her capture.

Neither option guaranteed her survival, but she wasn't exactly ready to crack her skull open.

She took her free arm and used it to elbow Eric on the side of his neck. As the boy doubled over in pain, coughing, Mina lunged forward and scrambled up the stairs into the dark attic. She moved around cautiously so as to not trip over something but quickly as she heard Eric's feet bounding up the stairs behind her.

She stood, hands feeling on the walls for a window she could escape through, but was blinded as a bright light illuminated the room. Eric had reached the top and flipped the light switch.

Eyes still adjusting to the light, she had moved to the side and collided with something, making her hit the floor with a thud. Blinking rapidly to clear her vision, Mina shrieked at the sight she saw. It wasn't *something* she had collided with, but *someone*. She sat there horrified as the soulless unblinking body of Eric's father towered over her.

"I see you've found them," Eric spoke amused, unfazed by his friend's terror. Mina's eyes moved to see the rest of his family standing around the father, all with the same emotionless look.

"I was keeping them up here until everyone was ready," he went on to explain. "Then I could get everything set up. Oh well, shouldn't be long now, just gotta take care of you."

As she saw Eric pull out the pocketwatch, Mina scrambled to her feet and began scanning the room for exits. On the other side of the room, she took notice of a window that led onto the roof and bolted for it. She tugged and tugged but to no avail. The window, probably not being opened in decades, wouldn't budge.

Eric sighed out in a mixture of disappointment and pity as he watched her struggle. "I don't even know why you're fighting this Mina," he slowly walked toward her. "This is the best solution! We can all still be together. No one has to go to move away to stupid England or go off to college. We can all stay here where we *belong*."

At this, Mina had to turn around. "Really? *This* is the best solution? Do you even hear yourself? Do you even realize what you're doing right now? Keeping your friends and family held captive is not only *illegal* but *PSYCHOTIC!*" She shouts at him.

"But we'd be apart if it wasn't for me!"

"We can still visit each other!"

"You know you can't afford the plane fare for that."

"Then we'll call! Text! Write each other a damn letter! Anything but this!" She shrieks.

"It's not enough." He mumbles as he shakes his head, looking at the ground.

He moves his hand up and put the watch in front of Mina's face, and uses the other to hold her jaw in place.

Closing her eyes shut as tightly as she can she squirms against his grip, trying for any means of escape.

"You can't fight me forever Mina."

“And there we go.”

Eric dusts his hands off as he sits down on the middle cushion of his living room couch.

“Mmm,” he hums as he sniffs the air, a delicious aroma filling his nostrils. “That smells good mom. Whatcha making?” he calls out to the kitchen.

“Chicken alfredo, honey. Your favorite. Just like you asked me to.” His mom calls back.

“I still don’t know why we couldn’t order pizza,” Eric’s sister Julia complains as she practices her pirouettes in the kitchen.

“Because Eric didn’t ask for pizza honey.” Their father speaks as he reads the paper at the kitchen counter. “Now sit down before you make yourself dizzy.”

“I’m glad we’re getting any kind of food besides this monstrosity,” Kira speaks beside Eric as she glares at the potato chips on the coffee table. “Hey, these chips are amazing.” Eric retorts.

“I assume you kids will be staying for dinner.” His mother calls out to the group of friends.

“I mean your son’s kept us here for the past 48 hours, might as well feed us,” Mina speaks coming back from Eric’s other side. “Oh classic Mina,” Eric chuckles.

“Hey, I’m really glad your family decided to stay man,” Matt speaks from his chair on the side.

“Yeah... me too,” Eric responds, satisfaction on his face.

A comfortable silence sets over the house as the group goes back to watching whatever cartoon was on the television.

“Me too.”

ALTERNATE/EXTENDED ENDING:

“Ya know, I *really* wish the school would stop calling,” Eric complains as he takes the phone’s receiver out of his dad’s hand. After the first week of missing attendance, the school was beginning to get concerned about the whereabouts of the four teenagers.

They began calling their homes in an attempt to contact their parents, but for the three hostages, the attempts were futile. Eric had already stopped by their houses and compelled their parents into delusion. Any question of the whereabouts of their children was met with “Oh, they’re still not feeling well. I think there’s some kind of nasty virus going around.” But they just wouldn’t let up. At this point, Eric was ready to say they had all moved to New Mexico or something.

“Alright, back to the game,” Eric lets out a groan and sigh as he takes his spot on the living room couch. “Matt, your turn.”

“Ok, what’s the color? Blue?” Matt takes a second to look at his deck of UNO cards, and his face falls in disappointment. “Looks like I’m drawing a card...again.” He plucks a red card from the deck and puts it in his hand as Kira observes her deck next to him.

“Hmm, let’s see,” She hums. “How about-”

“You know I can see your deck right?” Eric speaks from her other side.

“What? No, you can’t.” She retorts but scoots closer to Matt anyway.

“Two reds, three greens, and a color-changing draw four.” He deadpans.

“Well, just because you don’t respect the rules of UNO privacy,” she picks the draw four out of her hand and places it on the deck. “Draw four whore.”

“Well you see, I could do that...” Eric pulls another color-changing draw four from his deck and places it down. “Or I could just let Mina draw eight.”

Mina looks from her hand of at least 12 cards (that Eric had forced her to draw as well) to the draw four on the table to Eric, who only had 2 cards left. “Go ahead, babe,” he urges. Mina feels her blood run cold with irritation and she freezes in her spot. That *word*. He wouldn’t stop calling her that *word*.

“You know what? I never wanted to play anyway,” she slams her cards on the table and stands up, getting ready to walk away.

“Oh my god,” Eric laughs at her childish actions. “Babe you are such a sore loser.”

“And you’re an asshole.” She retorts.

“C’mon, where are you going? Stay, finish the game!” He calls out.

“No thanks!” she says walking away.

Matt and Kira share a panicked glance.

Eric's face darkens as a frown sets in. He rose from his seat, hand moving to clutch something in his sweatshirt pocket. "Sit down, Mina." He demands.

Mina stops in the hall, feet planted firmly on the ground. What should she do? Stay here? Keep walking? Go back to her seat? A thick tension coats the air as the whole house waits for her.

Ever since Eric had learned how to hypnotize people with that pocketwatch of his grandfathers, he became some kind of evil puppetmaster. Learning and studying the object until he had basically mastered it. Making people do what he wanted them to just with the sound of his voice. And if you disobeyed him or did anything to dismantle his perfect little home, well...

When Mina hadn't come back into the living room Eric was already getting pissed off and turned to follow the path that she had taken out, pocket watch in hand. "Seems like I need to up the dosage-"

His words get caught in his mouth, another eerie silence flowing through the house. Matt and Kira share a worried glance, but it soon turns into confusion, and then relief when they hear Eric's loud laughter bouncing off the hallway walls.

"Now that is clever," Eric laughs, doubled over and hand clutching the wall for support. Mina sits on the floor in the middle of the hallway, staring up at his laughing figure.

"I told you to sit down, and you literally just sat down! Hah!" he wipes a tear from his eye. "Oh, that's hilarious. You see, it's that sense of humor that I fell in love with."

Mina doesn't dare say a word as she waits, assessing his emotions.

Eric's laughter dies down and in what seems like an instant his smiling face has shifted into an annoyed stoic expression. "Now sit back down," he commands. "In the *living room*."

The group finishes their game, Eric winning of course, and the rest of the evening continues as usual. Eric's mom makes the nightly meal of spaghetti that he just can't seem to get tired of, everyone is given a nice dose of pocket watching, and all the soulless bodies are sent back up to the attic for a night of staring at the wall while Eric sleeps like a baby in the comfort of his own insanity.

Or at least that's what he thinks as the sounds above his head are drowned out by his snores.

Like clockwork, Mina pulls the old sheet off her head, squinting to see in the dark. Crouching down on the ground, she finds the flashlight she had planted and turns it on, illuminating the gloomy attic.

She's been following the same routine for weeks now. Once Eric had decided he was done playing with them and stored them all away in the attic for the night, she stopped her charade.

When he cornered her up in the attic that fateful day, holding her down so he could control her, she learned of a miraculous ability she had.

She couldn't be hypnotized.

Upon realizing this, she quickly feigned helplessness. She knew she wouldn't be making it out of that house alive so she did the only thing she could. Pretend. She made her body limp and devoided her eyes of emotion.

"There," Eric lets out a tired sigh of relief when she finally stops struggling against him. "Now was that so hard?"

Taking her by the shoulders, he walks her over to his family. Positioning her right next to his little sister. “Now you stay here while I go get the others,” he smiles brightly. Mina tries to control her breathing as tears prick her eyes. “Then we’ll all finally be right where we belong.”

She watches as the boy walks over to the stairs and disappears below them. A large breath exits her lungs and she doubles over onto her knees. “How? How did I-?” She questions confused and frantic. Why was she the only one who wasn’t able to be hypnotized? The whole situation was absurd to her, but she was determined to find out what made her different from the others. And she was determined to get everyone out of there. But that meant she couldn’t have her cover blown.

So for days and weeks on end she pretended and did everything Eric asked of her. The more time she spent around him, the more she saw just how sick he was. When things didn’t go his way, he’d throw a fit. He’d force them to play along to his little made-up stories.

And possibly the worst of it all, he was absolutely *obsessed* with her.

It would start with paying more attention to her than the others. He would buy her new clothes with his parent's credit cards. Have his mother cook her favorite foods. Even *feed* her. Sometimes he would simply neglect the others, so obsessed with her that he wouldn’t even feed them or take them out of the attic some days.

But yesterday was the last straw. Dressed up in a new tuxedo, Eric led Mina down the attic stairs and handed her a dress to go in the bathroom and change. Mina stared at her reflection in the long black satin dress, perplexed. Bags hung under her red eyes as she narrowed them. She was exhausted, playing his games. How long was she gonna have to keep this up? What was his goal with all of this? Well, she was about to find out.

After stepping out of the hallway bathroom, Eric led her out to the kitchen. The lights were dimmed and candles decorated the counters, their light, casting shadows on the wall. Jazz music played softly in the background as Eric pulled out a seat for her to sit in. Trying not to show the shock on her face, she carefully sat down and watched warily as Eric sat across from her. In the middle of the table sat a vase with a single rose and shiny polished silverware sparkled under the light.

“Do you like it?” Eric asked, peering down at her.

No. You’re a psychopath.

“I love it.” She smiled.

“I knew you would,” he blushes, looking down. “And this isn’t even the best part. Waiter!” Eric makes a show of clapping his hands over his shoulder and in seconds, Matt appears at Eric's side. His hair is disheveled and he stinks from neglect, but his appearance contrasts the shiny dome-covered plate in his hand.

“Your main entree for tonight, a fresh grilled three-cheese sandwich,” he smiles at the couple as he sets their plate down. Glancing at Mina, a look of panic flashes in his eyes and it doesn’t go unnoticed. Something is very wrong. But before he can elaborate, Eric dismisses him.

“See? It's your favorite,” Eric nods down at the plate. Forcing a thankful voice, Mina responds “You remembered? You’re so thoughtful. Thank you for this.”

“Anything for you. Now you’re probably wondering what all of this is about.”

No shit, you maniac.

“I’ve really been cherishing our time together these past couple of weeks, as I’m sure you have as well.”

“Of course.” *I’m gonna puke.*

“So I’ve been thinking, since we’re already living together, and you’ve already met my parents,” he chuckles. “I think we should take things to the next level.”

Trying to hide the nervous quiver in her voice, she questions “Like dating?”

“No, not exactly,” he smirks.

Oh, thank god.

Suddenly, Eric crouches on the ground in front of her, getting on one knee. She can’t help the shock that overtakes her face as he pulls out a small black box.

“Mina, will you marry me?” He looks up at her with hopeful eyes but all she can do is look back at him stunned and speechless.

Not getting the immediate answer he wanted, his hopeless expression turns annoyed.

“Say it.” He raises his voice. “SAY YES” he yells louder.

“YES!” she yells back in fear. Fear of him. Fear of the future.

“Good,” he calms down and sits back in his seat with a satisfied smile. “I love you.”

“I love you too.”

She was trying to take her time and do this right, but she couldn’t wait any longer. She had to get them out of there as soon as possible.

After sitting through that awful dinner they all returned to their places in the attic. After Eric disappears down the stairs, Mina wastes no time getting her flashlight and box from underneath the floorboard. Removing the lid she pulls out the cloth-wrapped piece of glass. Quickly unwrapping the stained shard, she presses it to her finger. Pressing down to create drops of blood, she rushes over to the idle figures around her. After pulling the sheets from their heads,

she holds her finger up to each of their mouths, making sure the metallic liquid gets into their systems.

The practice may be gross, but it was necessary. Spending night after night looking for answers as to why she couldn't be hypnotized she had finally found the holy grail. Tucked away in a moving box was a book, detailing the process of hypnosis. That must've been where Eric had learned it from. She searched the book for any explanation she could and finally, when she got to the end she found it. A paragraph explained the concept of the lover's shield. One could not hypnotize someone they loved, for if they truly cared for them, they would not want to take advantage of them. And one could protect oneself from the effects of hypnosis by ingesting the blood of a loved one of the hypnotizer. Armed with this knowledge she looked for the first sharp object she could find and tested it out for herself. Indeed it had worked, but not completely. She could only produce enough blood to give them the ability to form their own thoughts and expressions. They still couldn't move on their own free will, but this was better than nothing. And because Eric had made sure to pocket-watch each of them at least once a day, the effect didn't last very long. It was sad that his own family didn't have lover's shields of their own, but she was glad that she could help them, even if it only was a little.

Reaching back into the box, she pulls out a folded piece of paper. She unfolds it and lets out a heavy sigh. The plan she had been working on for weeks was finally going to be set in motion. She would take the night to perfect it, but 24 hours from then they would make their escape.

She crouches down on the floor feeling around for the floorboard. After lifting it out of place she frowns, growing confused when she can't find the flashlight after the usual amount of time it takes.

Where is it? I know I put it back in here earlier.

Suddenly, a bright light flashes in her eyes, blinding her. She reaches a hand over her eyes in an attempt to block the light. The figure of a tall person stands before her and she falls to the ground, dread overtaking her.

“Looking for something?” The figure jokes.

She can feel the blood drain from her face upon hearing the voice.

Eric.

“Aren't you supposed to be standing there? Limp and emotionless?” He nods over to the other bodies. “Why aren't you?”

She tried hard to think of an excuse to give him. Anything to keep him from blowing up. But she couldn't. Her mind was blank.

“Well I found your flashlight,” he continues, waving the object in the air. “Clearly. And your little box too.”

Fighting back tears, she stares back at him as he talks.

“Did you even mean it?” He asks, clenching his jaw. “When you told me you loved me.”

“Yes, of course.” Just tell him what he wants to hear. “You know that I-”

“Then why are you trying to leave me?!” He yells, walking closer.

Scared, Mina stands to her feet, backing away.

“Why are you hurting yourself?!” He reaches for her hand and holds it up between them.

“You are *making* me do this, Eric!” Mina yells back into his face, yanking her hand down. She’s had enough.

“I’m making you do this? I can’t even control you! I never could!”

Mina’s face contours in confusion. “Y-you knew?” She whispers.

“Of course, I knew, I LOVE YOU!” He grabs her shoulders. “I knew you were pretending but I thought you were pretending for *me*. Because you didn’t *want* to leave. I thought you had finally seen it my way.”

“Your way? You are crazy!”

“In love! That’s why I asked you to marry me!”

“Well, why don’t you love your family?! Huh!? Why does it take me giving them my blood to even give them a chance of hope?”

“Because they were trying to take me away from you, baby. You have to understand, I did this for us, for our love,” he holds her face in his hands.

“No,” she turns away. “No, there is no us. There is no *love*.” She rips herself out of his hold.

“What?”

“I don’t love you. But I care for you, so I’m trying to tell you that you need help. So let me go get you help,” she holds her hands up in front of her as she backs away. As she does so, she notices his hand glide into his pocket.

“I don’t need help, all I need is you,” he whispers as he pulls the glass shard out of his pocket.

Mina’s eyes go wide at the sight of the glass, her blood still staining it.

Gripping the sharp object in his hand he takes a few steps toward her. “All I need is you.” He hangs his head for a second, but before she knows it he’s lunging at her. Instantly going into fight or flight, she rushes to the side. She hisses in pain as the glass slices her arm.

“AH,” she falls to the ground in pain in front of Kira’s feet.

Observing the blood that drips from the glass down his arm, Eric looks appalled. “Look what you made me do!”

Though out of breath and in pain, Mina still tries to get to her feet. Her chance is cut short though, when she finds Eric lunging the piece of glass at her again. Ducking onto the ground again, Mina narrowly escapes the blade.

Panting, out of breath, Mina slowly raises her eyes. The shard sits just above her head, dug into Mina’s stomach. A drop falls onto her head, running down her forehead. Face hung in shock, she stares at the blood in her hand sobbing.

“I-” Eric stutters in shock, glass still stuck in her abdomen. “I didn’t mean to. I swear.”

“Get off her!” She yells, tackling him to the ground. In a fit of apologies, he rolls on the floor, trying to get her off of him, dropping the glass in the process. “Mina calm down!”

“You killed her! You are a monster!” She beats harshly on his chest in an attempt to hurt him, but he overpowers her, pinning her to the ground. “You’re acting crazy!”

“You’re a monster!” She shouts over and over, kicking from underneath her.

“Stop! I don’t want to hurt you!” He yells in her face. “I lo-”

Eric’s cries of affection are abruptly cut to an end, as his face goes devoid from above her. Mina gasps as the boy is thrown to the side.

Standing over her is a worn-out and pale Kira, glass shard in hand, now covered with the blood of their friend.